organization. You will get gratuity benefits if you serve for a minimum of 5 years, and the gratuity amount is not a small amount by any means. Remember that once you move to a new organization, you have to prove yourself once again, and this takes at least 6 – 12 months. So, unless, there is a drastic change in your salary, it does not make any financial sense to change jobs before completing at least 5 years with your current organisation.

Mutual funds

If you have never dealt with stocks before, mutual funds are the place to start. Some of my recommendations regarding mutual fund investments are.

- Start investing in mutual funds within 12 months of the start of your financial freedom journey.
- Make sure you have an online account so that you can track the status in real time. Now a days, you can open mutual fund accounts online if you have a valid PAN number~[52] and the PAN number is registered with Know Your Customer (KYC~[53]) office. When I started with Reliance Mutual Funds, I had to fill in forms manually, but now I can create online mutual fund accounts with other mutual fund houses as well.
- Start investing in mutual funds with a small monthly Systematic Investment Plan (SIP) and continue this way for about 12 months. I started off with ₹1000/- monthly SIP investments with Reliance mutual funds.
- This is the first time you might feel excited about the returns,which can be 15 to 20% in a year (I have realized even 100% returns! No, this is not a mistake!) or you may realize that your money actually gave you negative returns in a specific time period. You must get used to either feeling of volatility. This will set some long-term perspectives in your mind. In the long run, you are more likely to win in the equity market since your fund is professionally managed in mutual funds. You will learn to cope with the day to day ups and downs of the markets and the mutual funds. In the long run (7+ years), you can expect good mutual